# Making the Melody Sing

Balance, phrase direction, articulation, pedal and deliberate expressive timing.

## How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

## In this chapter

1. Bring out the melody
2. Shape a phrase toward its arrival
3. Connect and release intentionally
4. Clear pedal changes
5. Expression without losing the pulse
6. Abide with Me: a singing line
7. Just As I Am: clear pedalling
8. It Is Well with My Soul
9. Abide with Me

## 1. Bring out the melody

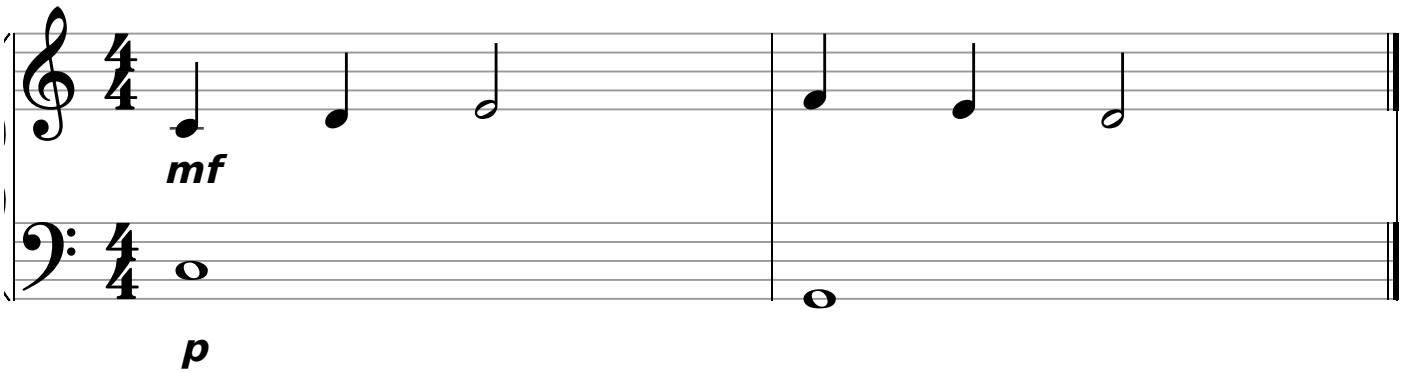
Play two different sound levels at the same time.

### Bring out the melody

Imagine one singer with a quiet accompaniment. First play the melody alone and decide its sound. Add the left hand so lightly that the tune remains easy to follow. Louder melody does not mean a tense right hand: use a supported arm movement and less left-hand weight. A phone cannot reliably measure the balance between individual chord tones.

#### Practise · Melody over quiet bass

Sing the right-hand line while keeping the left hand soft.




Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Reverse the roles

Now listen to the left hand as a melody. Keep the right-hand chords very soft.

#### Listen and check

Listen back if you can record on your own device. Can you hum the featured line without concentrating? If not, reduce the accompanying hand.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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## 2. Shape a phrase toward its arrival

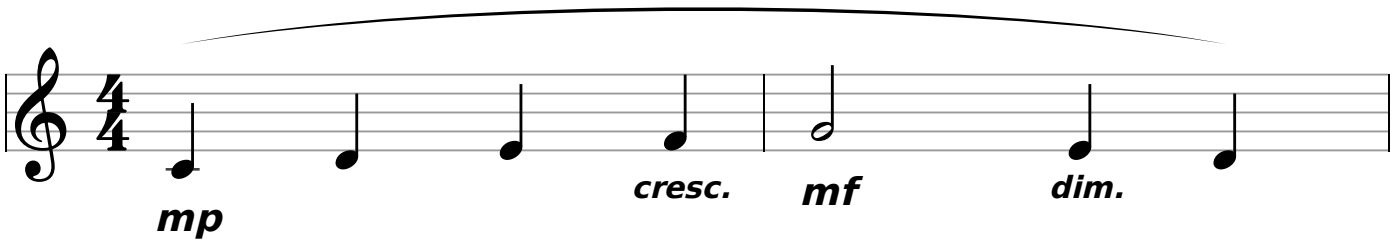
Use a clear destination instead of swelling on every note.

#### Shape a phrase toward its arrival

Sing the melody and notice where it wants to arrive. Choose one destination note in a phrase; grow toward it gently, then release the energy. The highest note is not automatically the loudest. A breath between phrases should not become an extra beat unless the music calls for it.

### Practise · One destination

Let G be the arrival. Ease away through the second bar.




Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · An answering phrase

Make the second phrase a gentler answer.

#### Listen and check

Mark the arrival note before playing. Does the phrase sound like one sentence, or like a separate accent on every beat?

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

## 3. Connect and release intentionally

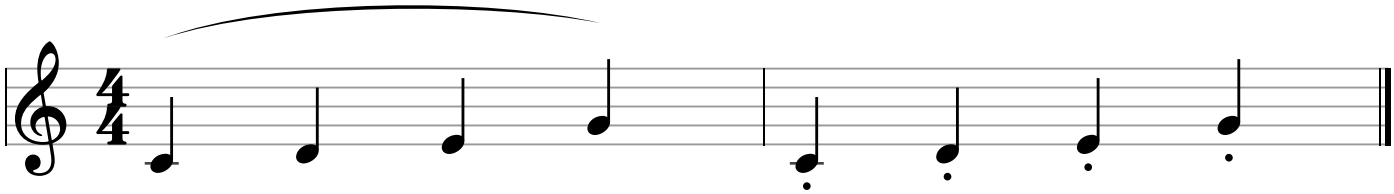
Separate legato, detached notes and phrase endings.

### Connect and release intentionally

Legato means connected sound, not fingers pressed harder into the key bed. Release a finger as the next note takes over. Detached notes have a deliberate space; staccato needs a light release rather than a large bounce. Practise without pedal so your fingers create the connection.

### Practise · Connected then detached

Make the first group smooth and the second light.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Phrase-end release

Let the final half note last fully, then use the written rest to breathe.

### Listen and check

Can you hear the difference without looking at your hands? Check that the phrase-end rest is silence rather than lingering pedal.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

## 4. Clear pedal changes

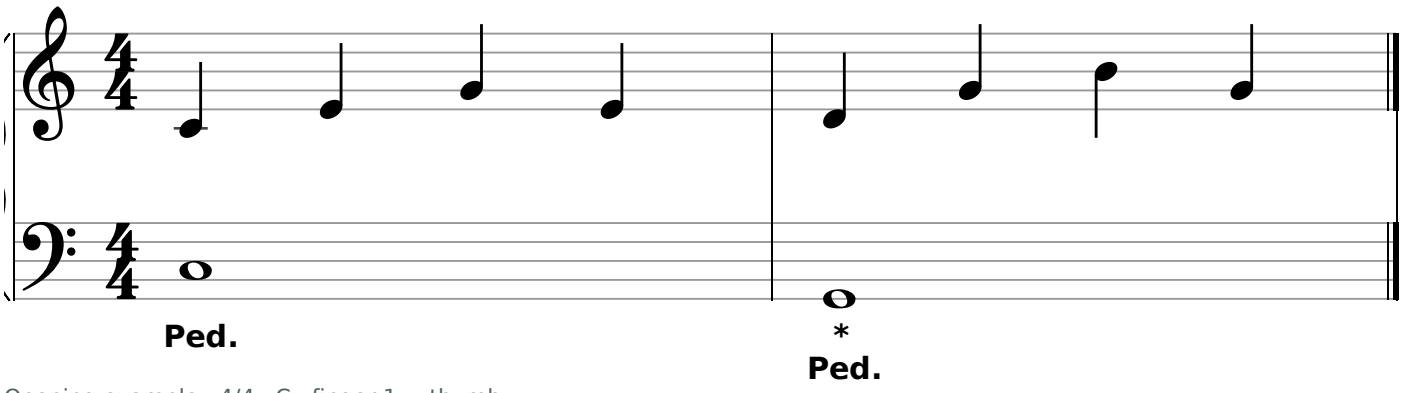
Change just after a new harmony sounds.

### Clear pedal changes

First learn the notes without pedal. For a connected pedal change, play the new harmony, lift the old pedal immediately, then press again while the new keys are still held. This clears the old harmony without leaving a large gap. Keep the heel supported. Room acoustics and piano resonance decide how much pedal is useful.

### Practise · Two harmonies

Coordinate the pedal change after the new bass sounds.




Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Clean final release

Lift at the rest, then finish without a blur.

### Listen and check

Listen without watching the pedal. Do the old chord tones disappear after each change? On a very resonant piano, use less pedal or practise without it.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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## 5. Expression without losing the pulse

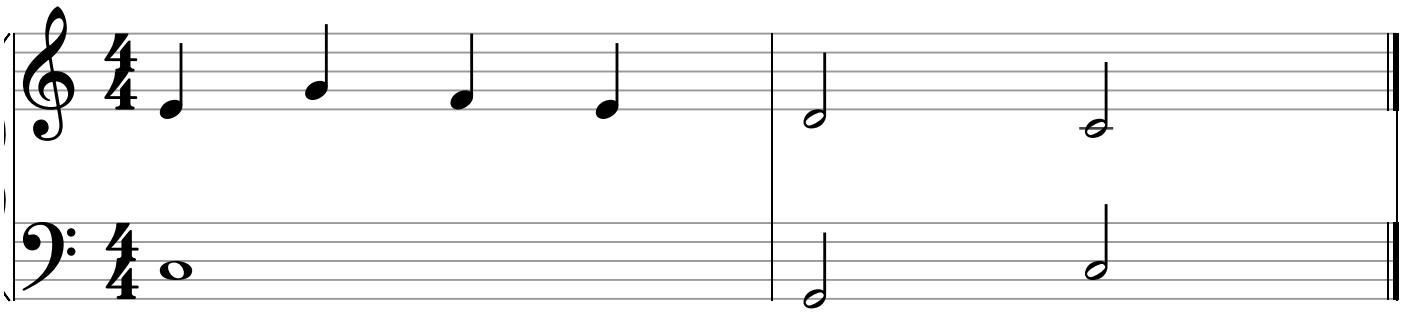
Choose where to broaden and how to recover the tempo.

### Expression without losing the pulse

A phrase can breathe while its pulse remains understandable. First play in strict time. Then choose a small easing at the final cadence and return to the original tempo for the next phrase. Repeated hesitation at a hard bar is a practice problem, not expressive timing. Use the ordinary lesson for expressive runs; Flow expects steadier note starts.

### Practise · First, strict time

Keep this balanced phrase exactly in time.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Plan the final arrival

Play in time first; then try a small broadening only at the final C.

#### Listen and check

Could you describe exactly where you changed the timing? Repeat the hard bar in strict time to check that your choice is deliberate.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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## 6. Abide with Me: a singing line

Sing each phrase first. Choose one destination and keep the left hand below the melody in volume.

#### What to listen for

Sing each phrase first. Choose one destination and keep the left hand below the melody in volume.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

### Practise · Melody alone

Sing each phrase first. Choose one destination and keep the left hand below the melody in volume.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

### Practise · Opening together

Sing each phrase first. Choose one destination and keep the left hand below the melody in volume.

### Practise · Abide with Me: a singing line

Sing each phrase first. Choose one destination and keep the left hand below the melody in volume.

**Your musical check**

Can a listener hum the melody without concentrating on it?

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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## 7. Just As I Am: clear pedalling

Learn the notes without pedal. Add small, clean changes only after the new harmony sounds. This source uses 6/4.
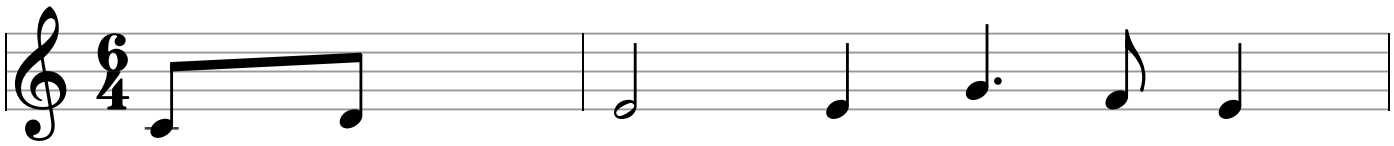
**What to listen for**

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### Practise · Melody alone

Learn the notes without pedal. Add small, clean changes only after the new harmony sounds. This source uses 6/4.



Opening example · 6/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

### Practise · Opening together

Learn the notes without pedal. Add small, clean changes only after the new harmony sounds. This source uses 6/4.

### Practise · Just As I Am: clear pedalling

Learn the notes without pedal. Add small, clean changes only after the new harmony sounds. This source uses 6/4.

### Your musical check

Listen for old harmonies blurring across the changes; reduce pedal if needed.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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## 8. It Is Well with My Soul

Keep the melody prominent, connect phrases and clear the pedal when the harmony changes.

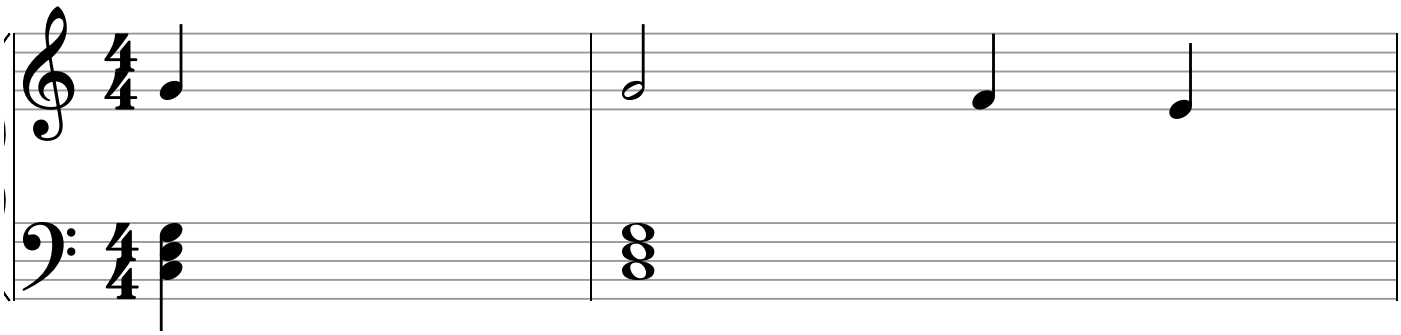
### Prepare your recital

Keep the melody prominent, connect phrases and clear the pedal when the harmony changes.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

### Practise · Dress rehearsal: It Is Well with My Soul

Keep the melody prominent, connect phrases and clear the pedal when the harmony changes.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Keep the melody prominent, connect phrases and clear the pedal when the harmony changes.

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## 9. Abide with Me

Shape a singing melody above a quiet bass, connect the phrases and use clear pedal changes where the harmony calls for them.

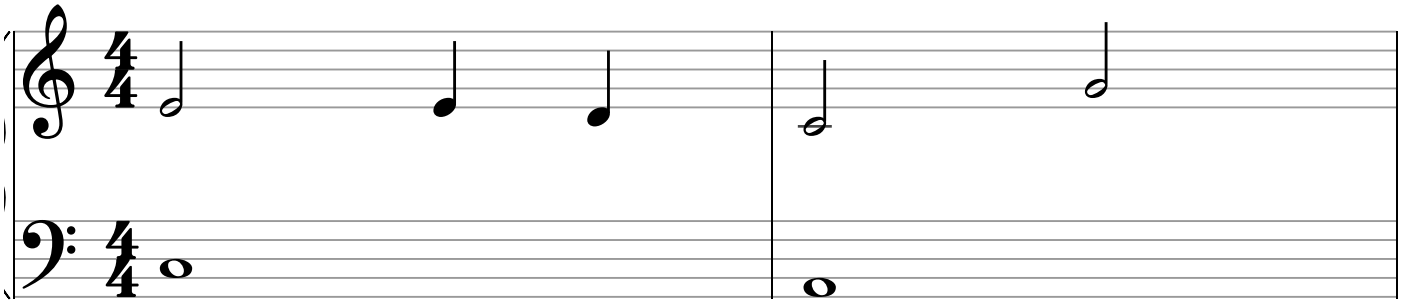
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Shape a singing melody above a quiet bass, connect the phrases and use clear pedal changes where the harmony calls for them.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

### Practise · Dress rehearsal: Abide with Me

Shape a singing melody above a quiet bass, connect the phrases and use clear pedal changes where the harmony calls for them.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

### Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Shape a singing melody above a quiet bass, connect the phrases and use clear pedal changes where the harmony calls for them.

## Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Play two different sound levels at the same time.
- ☐ Use a clear destination instead of swelling on every note.
- ☐ Separate legato, detached notes and phrase endings.
- ☐ Change just after a new harmony sounds.
- ☐ Choose where to broaden and how to recover the tempo.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, a clear melody, steady pulse and comfortable movement.

**My next practice goal**

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**What sounded better? What still needs work?**

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